The waters from Indira Col drain in the south to the Siachen Glacier and to the Nubra and Shyok rivers, to finally merge with the Indus.[22] If Indian control was eliminated from this region, modern hydro-engineering could increase the flow of the Indus right up to and beyond Turtuk, the last village on the Indian side of the LoC. This would lead to a much more intense flow of the river and consequently make the generation of electricity much easier in the future.[23] Waters to the north of Indira Col would drain into the Urdok Glacier, Shaksgam River, Yarkand River, Tarim and Qyurug rivers to merge with the Lop Nor Lake in Sinkiang, close to China's nuclear testing site.[24]

It is clear that China's interest in the Shaksgam Valley was largely because of the waters of the four rivers that flow through it.[25] The country was setting up Lop Nor in Sinkiang as a nuclear testing site and in the event that the Lop Nor Lake was contaminated or it dried up, it wanted to ensure an available supply of water to the region. In 1962, China was still a non-nuclear nation and was yet to invade Ladakh and Arunachal Pradesh, then known as NEFA. For China to enter secret negotiations with Pakistan during those days, required a lot of courage because Pakistan, through its membership of SEATO and CENTO, was a frontline state against communism. What did China and Pakistan discuss during those talks? Did the Government of India have any intelligence inputs on them or did the agreement in 1963 come as a big shock to Nehru?[26]

Further, after the Sino-Indian War of 1962, China established *de jure* control over Aksai Chin in India. After encroaching into Aksai Chin in 1954 to build a road linking Sinkiang and Tibet, China was able to take over the Aksai Chin Lake, which is fed by Aksai River and many other streams. Its closed catchment occupies an area of about 8,000 sq km.[27]

As a result, the Chinese quest for water originating in the Karakoram-Himalaya region[28] has resulted in the Chinese acquiring Aksai Chin in Ladakh by force and the Shaksgam Valley in Gilgit-Hunza by an illegal treaty with Pakistan.[29] This farsighted Chinese planning has resulted in a windfall gain for them today. The only joker in the pack is India's right to exploit 19.48 per cent of river water of the three rivers flowing through the